

Icy nurseries

Many seals breed on the pack ice that forms on the polar oceans, and in the Southern Ocean around Antarctica this is a very safe strategy. In the Arctic, the threat posed by hunting polar bears has led to the evolution of special adaptations and patterns of behavior that reduce the risk of a deadly attack.

SNOW CAVE

Ringed seals live near the North Pole, where they breed on snowy sea ice attached to the shore. Each female burrows up through a crack in the ice to dig a cave in the tumbled ice and snow. Her pup stays in the cave while she slips out through the secret entrance to go hunting. This means that both of them are always hidden from prowling polar bears.



WOW!

Harp seals rear their young for just 12 days, then leave them on the ice. The vulnerable pups cannot swim or hunt for another six weeks.

ON THIN ICE

Unlike ringed seals, harp seals live in big colonies. In late winter, they travel to three breeding areas on the Atlantic fringes of the Arctic, and the females gather on newly formed pack ice to have their single pups. The thin ice is strong enough for the seals, but too fragile to support the much heavier polar bears that prey on them. However, the ice breaks up quickly, so the pups have to grow up fast.

▲ HARP SEAL NURSERY

Four harp seal pups and an adult female bask on the sea ice off the eastern coast of Arctic Canada.

